CINEMA

Films with a DIFFerence

After two pandemic-induced online editions, the 11th edition of Dharamshala International Film Festival (DIFF) is back with a physical edition in McLeodganj from November 3 to 6. The lineup, meant to showcase the finest films from India and abroad, does an especially masterful job of spotlighting the diversity and sheer talent of independent films from the subcontinent. Here are some films to look out for:


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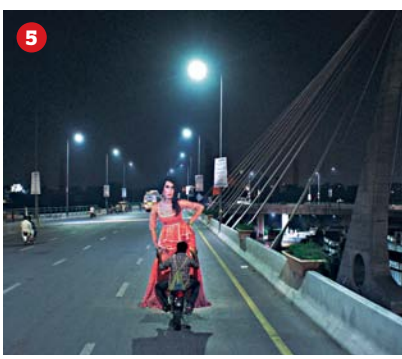
1 URF: Geetika Narang Abbasi's documentary puts a spotlight on the eccentric, heartfelt, and tragic lives of several lookalikes of Bollywood superstars. Focusing mainly on Firoz Khan a.k.a. Jr Amitabh Bachchan, Kishore Bhanushali a.k.a. Jr Dev Anand and Prashant Wade a.k.a. Jr Shah Rukh Khan, *Urf* is a fascinating portrait of stardom and anonymity in a cinema-obsessed country.

2 FIRE IN THE MOUNTAINS: Set in the majestic Himalayas, Ajitpal Singh's debut feature is a plucky subversion of a woman's place in a patriarchal society. Depicting a very specific female experience that rarely ever makes its way to the screen, *Fire in the Mountains* complements its unhurried narrative with splendid visual flourishes and a keen eye for detail.

3 ALL THAT BREATHES: There is perhaps no other Indian film that has documented the state of the nation as beautifully as Shaunak Sen's gorgeously mounted Sundance-winning documentary. A masterclass in filmmaking and empathy, and a potential Oscar contender, *All That Breathes* is an urgent examination of the dignity of life—both human and animal—in modern India.

4 POKHAR KE DUNU PAAR (ON EITHER SIDE OF THE POND): It's a good bet that if Anurag Kashyap lends his name to an indie film, it's worth checking out. Set against the backdrop of the pandemic, debutant director Parth Saurabh's *Pokhaar Ke Dunu Paar* is an acutely-observed drama that illuminates the stark realities of privilege, gender hierarchies and economic insecurities that make up an India we tend to look away from.

5 JOYLAND: Saim Sadiq's *Joyland*, Pakistan's official entry to the Oscars, is a sensitively realised queer coming-of-age drama that sparkles with its vibrancy, detailing and commitment to upend conventional narratives. The Urdu-language


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film, which will have its India Premiere at DIFF, looks at transgender lives, rights and desires with a humane affection that becomes necessary and moving.

6 JHINI BINI CHADARIYA (THE BRITTLE THREAD): First-time filmmaker Ritesh


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